



DIAPHRAGMA

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PLAYERS RULEBOOK

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What Is Diaphragma?

WHAT IS DIAPHRAGMA?



Welcome to **Diaphragma**, a modular narrative RPG built for fast, cinematic play, expressive storytelling and designed to be expanded through setting Frameworks. You'll read the room, find the angle, use your surroundings, exploit the weakness, and strike when everything lines up. When the dice hit the table, you've already done the work. Let's tell great stories!

"The guard patrols the same arc. Every thirty seconds, the doorway is empty.

You've counted four passes. The lantern inside throws his shadow before he reaches the window — that's your warning. The mud will muffle your steps. The broken shutter gives you two handholds.

You don't move until the moment is right. When you do, it counts."

DRINKS Something to keep the table going.

SNACKS Essential. Non negotiable.

Each story runs on a **Framework**, a setting layer your Storyteller picks that gives you the world, the threats, and the tone. The rules handle the rest.

WHAT YOU NEED

DICE One d10.

SHEETS Character sheets PDF

FRIENDS 2–5 players and a Storyteller.

Why This Book Exists

WHY THIS BOOK EXISTS

I've run a lot of different games. I love a tactical fight, positioning, setup, finding the angle that wins the moment. I also love the sessions where a player stops describing what they do and starts describing who they are while they do it.

For a long time, those two things felt like they were working against each other. Tactical games rewarded careful mechanical play, but the narration got thin. Narrative games let the story breathe, but felt that I am missing some of that crunch that made a tactical play so rewarding. You can play narratively in a tactical game, but the system doesn't help you. That weight falls entirely on the players, and I felt like my tables can't sustain it during sessions.

What I wanted was a play style where doing the smart thing and telling a good story were both rewarded by the table. Sometimes you do the smart thing, sometimes you do the cool thing. Sometimes you do the crazy thing. Sometimes you do the stupid thing. But all of it is part of the story, and all of it is part of the table.

I also run a lot of one shots. Different settings every few weeks: a heist, a horror crawl, a war story. Every time I had to teach a new system or bend the tone to fit rules that weren't built for the genre. I wanted one engine I could trust across all of it, and change the world by swapping the Framework, not the rulebook.

Diaphragma is that engine.

This is my attempt to find that thin line between crunch and narrative freedom.

FOUR DESIGN COMMITMENTS

CINEMATIC

One roll covers a complex action. You describe the whole move and roll once.

RESOURCEFUL

Bonuses come from what is in the scene. The high ground you took, the darkness you moved through, the gear in your hand. Smart play earns real mechanical advantage.

EXPRESSIVE

Your character is built from lived experience. I trained as a soldier. I read law at university. That history is what you roll with. I want to enable the player to play the fantasy character they want to play

MODULAR

The core rules ship without a setting. They are designed to pair with a Framework, a layer your Storyteller builds that adds the world, the tone, and the genre. Same engine, different game.

"A game is a series of interesting choices."

SID MEIER

Core Concepts

CORE CONCEPTS

THE DIE

Diaphragma uses one die: a **d10**. Before you roll, choose to **Settle** for a fixed 5, or **Roll** and take what the die gives you. The result is then modified by Edges (+1 each) and Bains (-1 each).

Final result: 2–6 Failure, 7–9 Partial Success, 10+ Success.

A natural **1** is always a Critical Failure. A natural **10** is a Critical Success.



SETTLE OR ROLL

Before rolling, choose: **Settle** treats your result as 5, **Roll** means you pick up the d10 and take whatever comes.

EDGES & BAINS

Edges are favorable factors worth **+1** each: gear, position, preparation, enemy weakness. Bains are unfavorable factors that subtract **-1** each.

PARTIAL SUCCESS

A final result of 7–9. You progress the story, but the Storyteller adds a cost, complication, or new pressure.

NARRATIVE POINTS

A pool shared by all players. Earned when critical moments happen. Spend **1 NP** for cool effects or narrative boosts.

BURDENS

A flaw. When a Burden is relevant, the best possible result is **Partial Success**. Full Success is off the table regardless of Edges.

PROFICIENCIES & SPECIALTIES

Your character's background, written as lived experience. Determines what actions and gear you can invoke as Edges.

STORYTELLER TOKENS

The Storyteller's resource for pushing back. Spend **1 ST** to invoke a Bain against a player action. The Storyteller starts each scene with a set number. Burdens never cost ST.

FRAMEWORKS

A rules layer added on top of the core system. Each Framework defines a setting: its tone, character options, powers, gear, enemies, and any special rules.

PLAYS

Special abilities tied to a Framework. Things your character can do that the core rules do not cover: powers, maneuvers, and techniques defined by the setting.

LEGENDARY PLAYS

Created from a specific moment in play. Spends a **Legendary Token**, to make it a permanent ability

